

Developmental Leadership

In the book of Exodus, chapter 18, we meet the prophet Moses (Nebi Musa) as he is taking a break. Having brought his people out of Egypt, he is exhausted. His father-in-law, Jethro (Nebi Shaib), a Midianite priest, arrives suddenly with Moses's wife, Zipporah, and their two children, Gershom and Eleazar, in tow. This is the family Moses left behind when he was called to his mission in Egypt. When Jethro asks Moses how it's going, Moses complains about how hard it has been. Jethro then invites him to join him in praising God for having blessed him.

The next morning, Jethro goes to work with Moses as he starts his task of judging the people. Moses sits on the ground as people gather around him, towering over him with questions, claims, and demands. Jethro intervenes: "This is not good for you. And it is not good for the people. It will exhaust you both." He urges Moses to step back, select one man among each ten whom he judges to be "capable, God-fearing, and honest," educate him in the law, and authorize him to lead the others. Jethro, in other words, urges Moses to select, train, and delegate. Then, Jethro says, select one among these ten to do the same and so forth, until Moses can work directly with only ten people. This step will transform his life and that of his people. Moses acts on the plan immediately.

It's one thing to get good advice. But it's quite another to act on it quickly, especially if we ourselves are the source of the problem. Why did Moses put himself in this situation in the first place? Was he hungry for power? Why do we often wind up in the same spot? Was it maybe that he cared so much about getting it right that he couldn't risk someone else getting it wrong? Sound familiar?

Recall that Jethro's encounter with Moses in this story begins with Jethro reminding Moses that he is more than the leader of his people. He is a father. He is a husband. He is blessed by God. By restoring Moses's relationship with his family and with his God—sources of identity that transcend his work, giving him the courage to let go—Jethro enables Moses to risk giving up enough control to empower himself and his people.

Are you willing to give up enough control to let others lead so that you can develop the power you need to achieve your goals? Developing a leadership-rich organization depends on your answer to that question. As one of my students put it, the test of good leadership is not how many hats you can wear at the same time. It is how many people you can enable to wear hats.

An organizer's job is to identify, recruit, and develop leadership who can identify, recruit, and develop more leadership, who can identify, recruit, and develop more leadership in a cascade of leadership.

Why Developmental Leadership?

Powerful organizing requires the sustained development of leadership. Having defined leadership as accepting responsibility for enabling others to achieve shared purpose, previous chapters focused on five specific leadership practices critical to the practicing of democracy: relationship building, storytelling, strategizing, action, and structuring. The reason developmental leadership concludes this book rather than starts is because as a practice, it doesn't stand apart but is at the center of each of the practices described in previous chapters. Presenting developmental leadership here is an attempt at integration. It is also a reminder that this book is about what people can do together. That begins, however, with at least one person saying, "Yes, we can!"

Here, I focus the developmental dimension of the collaborative and distributive forms discussed in the last chapter. While fundamental to organizing, this approach can also be useful in domains where the value being created is the fruit of values-based motivation, collaboration, and sustained learning: healthcare, education, and the arts and culture, to name a few.

We are wise to distinguish authority from leadership. Authority describes the legitimacy of certain rules and of the power of those responsible to enforce those rules. Legitimacy grows out of compliance with agreed-upon practices as well as cultural beliefs. Organization is a way to formalize authority relations—people's rights and their obligations—among the participants. Bureaucracies structure authority as a set of rules according to the dictates of a manager. Markets structure authority as a set of rules according to which people make enforceable contracts based on their individual resources. Civic associations usually structure authority democratically, in that leaders are chosen by and accountable to the constituents they serve. Exercising

leadership in a civic, especially voluntary, setting can require more skill than in other settings because it depends more on persuasion than on command.¹

Most of us have been in situations where those with authority have not earned their leadership but try rather to compel cooperation based solely on their access to the power to dominate others. Cultures have institutionalized beliefs about who is authorized to lead, and who isn't, that may bar certain kinds of people from the opportunity to earn leadership. Leaders who develop under these conditions constitute a challenge to conventional ideas of authority. Once again, we see that leadership and authority are not the same thing.

Finally, we distinguish leaders from activists. Hardworking activists show up every day to staff the phone bank, pass out leaflets, and put up posters, making critical contributions to the work of any volunteer organization. This is not the same, however, as engaging others in doing the work of the organization. Effective leaders turn activists into leaders who can in turn activate others, but the process takes time and intentionality.

Because leadership is so important to organizing, we must make sure our constituency has the leadership it needs. Structure is important, but ultimately the effectiveness of organized people—especially in social movements or civic associations that try to bring people together, facilitate their mutual understanding, and enable them to act together on common interests—depends more on the depth of their leadership than on the efficiency of their systems.

Effective developmental leadership is built right into the work. A long-standing debate in the field of executive education is about the value of off-site training when it comes to sustained change. At the conclusion of any quality workshop, participants often experience a glow as they reflect on their new discoveries and dream of new possibilities. But it is often also the case that, after a limited time back on the job, old behavioral patterns return because nothing has changed in the structures of work that produced the old patterns in the first place. In other words, unless the work is structured in such a way as to develop newly desired practices, off-site executive training can only be of limited value in transforming managerial culture. The same truth applies for leadership practices in organizing.²

In this chapter we focus on ways to approach developmental leadership systematically. But like most things, these practices are most effective when used strategically. Particularly good organizers always have their antenna on alert for the one with the “sparkle in their eyes.” The one who asks

more questions, good questions, and learns from the responses, perhaps generating his or her own. The one who has people; that is, they're interacting with others as part of their MO, not as their acolytes but as their collaborators, their teammates. The one who takes pride when one of his mentees shines, rather than reacting as if they take the light away from him. Good organizers also have a plan. Hmm . . . this spot will be opening soon and it looks like Maria might be able to take it on . . . or it looks like David is stuck where he is. I wonder what would enable him to take the next step . . . Maybe Omar would be perfect to pair him up with. And so on.

Take a look at the leadership quotient of your organization. How many people hold real leadership responsibility? Is there one leader on whom everyone else depends, linked to that leader like spokes to the hub of a wheel? Or is no one linked to anyone else because there are no leaders, or because everyone is a leader? Or are some people always leaders and others always followers? Is the organization leadership rich, or is it leadership poor?

Developmental leadership requires a systematic commitment to identifying, recruiting, and developing the capacity of constituency-based individuals, teams, and communities in building the power needed to achieve the group's larger goals. Developing leadership doesn't happen with the depth or at the scale it needs to without intentionality. And without developing leadership, it is too easy to end up like the person in the image: all the arrows point at you, or they point nowhere.

Why Leadership Teams?

How can we structure the development of leadership committed to developing more leadership? Get started by asking yourself what kind of leader you want to be should be, and what you look for in others.³

Sometimes we think the leader is the person everyone goes to, like the "I'm the leader!" approach. But what does it feel like to be the leader in the middle, with all those arrows coming at you? And if you're not the leader, what does it feel like to be an arrow trying to get through? What happens if the leader in the middle drops out?

On the other hand, some of us question the whole concept of leadership. Shouldn't everyone be considered a leader? Is leadership really necessary? Isn't it repressively hierarchical? Why do we need this kind of structure at all (Figure 7.1)? Can't we just come together?

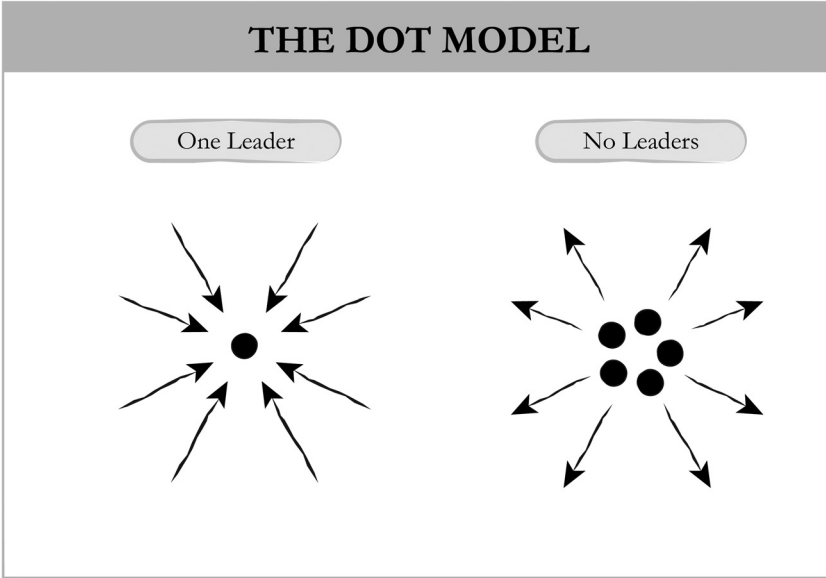


Figure 7.1 The Dot Model (previously appears in chapter 1 as Figure 1.8).
Source: Steve Downer of the Difference

Sometimes, against the odds, this approach works. But who's responsible for coordinating everyone? And who's responsible for moving the whole group forward when you can't reach a decision?

Since neither "I'm the leader" nor "we're all leaders" creates the conditions for effective democratic organizing, what are the alternatives? One option is building an interdependent leadership team that enables people to practice collaborative leadership on behalf of a shared purpose. Like a soccer team or a string quartet, each team member may lead with a particular practice (strategy, storytelling), function (data, communications), or constituency (downtown, the eastside, etc.), even if one of the roles is that of the captain, first violin, or coordinator. A well-designed team can also put the unique assets of each individual to work. Launching a leadership team creates strategic capacity: the ability to strategize with the creativity, salient information, and agility to produce more vibrant, situated, and engaging strategy than any one individual could create alone.

Despite the mythology of a lone alpha leader, most movement leaders led with teams: Moses, Aaron, and Miriam in Exodus; Jesus and his twelve disciples in the New Testament; the Buddha and his first sangha; the Prophet and

his companions in the Qur'an. In the Montgomery Bus Boycott, Dr. King, Ralph Abernathy, Rosa Parks, Jo Ann Robinson, and E. D. Nixon operated as a leadership team.

The sooner you can begin working with a team, the sooner your "I" can become a "we" of an organization. You can structure a regular rhythm of meeting, decision-making, accountability, and learning that enables real progress. No one can build a real organization of five hundred people by recruiting them all on their own. Instead, you build it by recruiting people willing and able to commit to building it with you. If you can't recruit them, it may be that they don't need you.

In the Obama campaign, the field structure enabled layers of leadership teams at all levels of the campaign. A state leadership team could coordinate regional leadership teams, who could coordinate volunteer neighborhood leadership teams. Although not always realized in practice, the idea was that people on teams at each level could focus on a shared mission and strategize together about how to fulfill that mission. This structure could create multiple points of entry for volunteers, real opportunities for learning, access to sustained coaching, and the actual responsibility for leadership.⁴

Why, then, doesn't everyone work in leadership teams?

Many leaders have only experienced dysfunctional teams. Perhaps a leader has never actually worked within what Richard Hackman called a real team at all. Perhaps the team was not structured to enable constructive conflict, lacked accountability measures, rarely learned from its mistakes, or let the work fall entirely on one person or on no one at all.

More specifically, they—or you—may have found yourself in a situation like the following:

- You are in a team meeting. But it's unclear who you can count on to step up, take responsibility, and get the work done. Two or three people often wind up doing all the work, which means that no matter how hard you work, you can't get it all done.

Whenever you need to decide, you always seem to be missing some crucial piece of information, skill, or set of relationships.

- You talk and talk and talk, but when it's all over, you realize that each person had a different idea of the outcome you were talking about.
- When you get stuck, you have nowhere else to turn for help. You help each other as much as you can, you may contact another volunteer leader, but it's not clear where you can go for expert advice.

In the face of so many bad experiences, it's tempting to throw up our hands in defeat: "I'll just do it on my own," we may conclude. "I hate meetings, just tell me what to do," we say. "I don't want any responsibility; just give me stamps to lick."

There's just one problem: your group can't ever become powerful enough to do what you need to do if you can't even work together as a self-governing leadership team. By drawing on the craft of team design, you can create conditions that increase the odds your team can work together successfully.

Launching Leadership Teams

Organizing is a craft. Leadership is a craft. Organizing a leadership team is a craft. We have learned a lot about how to do this in practice, based especially on the work of Richard Hackman: bounded, stable, and interdependent leadership teams that operate with a shared purpose, clear norms, and well-defined roles, with access to able coaching, are more likely to get results than teams that lack these structures.⁵

Three Outcomes of an Effective Team

An effective team has three clear goals and objectives, ultimately setting the organization up for future success. A successful team:

- ***Accomplishes the goals for which it is responsible:*** effective organizing enables groups to achieve their goal—pass the law, win the election, launch the credit union, make beautiful music, and so on.
- ***Operates in ways that make it better as a performing unit over time:*** effective organizing creates more collective capacity; stronger and/or deeper organization; new competencies; greater solidarity—not as a side benefit but as *the* core purpose.
- ***Contributes to the learning and well-being of individual members:*** effective organizing enables the development of leadership, not as a side benefit, but as a core purpose.

One may fail to achieve the goal yet wind up with a stronger organization, more power, and the ability to try again. Alternatively, one may achieve the

goal but wind up with a weakened organization, as in “I never want to see anyone involved in this campaign again” (a result of a scorched-earth approach). Focusing on the second and third outcomes along with the first inherently brings a longer term or more strategic perspective to choices about how to go about achieving the first goal.

Three Conditions for an Effective Team

An effective team is bounded, stable, and diverse.

When a team is bounded, it is clear who is on the team and who is not on the team. It is clear how new people can join the team and how people can leave the team.

People sometimes object that these conditions are downright wrong—no one should ever be excluded from anything. But a bounded team is not exclusionary just because it has clear expectations about what is required of those who serve, what the criteria of selection are, and why it has decided to operate the way it does. Consider teams that actually get things done: a basketball team, an airline cabin crew, a string quartet. How do you think it would work if anyone who showed up was on those teams? Why not bring that same principle to the work of social change?

When a team is stable, people commit to clear terms of engagement: regular meetings, a regular length of time, regular terms of service. The team is not a revolving door, with members never knowing who will show up.

Some organizers object that stability is unrealistic. People have busy lives. They can't always show up for meetings. Life happens. All of this is true. But we all make choices as to our commitments if we are to honor them, to feel good about ourselves, and to feel valued by others. Team commitments must be as clear as possible from the beginning, so I can have some idea of what I'm getting into and what is expected of me. When only half of the team shows up and half of the meeting is used to bring those who didn't show up last time up to date, a process repeated at meeting after meeting, too much time is wasted.

People who want to participate can contribute in many other ways besides serving on a leadership team, or any team for that matter. They may provide expertise when needed. They may participate in public events. They may share good ideas with a team member. But a person who can't or won't follow through should not accept the responsibilities that go with serving on a leadership team. Those who do accept membership on the leadership

team, moreover, need to feel that the costs of accepting that responsibility are worth it: the motivation must be strong (the cause really matters), the experience of making a difference real, and the opportunity for growth significant.

When a team is diverse, its members can contribute the range of skills, talents, viewpoints, and constituencies needed to accomplish their goals. In this way, leadership can be understood not as a one-person-who-is-good-at-everything job. On the contrary, it is a job that requires the interdependent strength of many.

Some leaders object that they just don't have access to the appropriate diversity of skills, talents, viewpoints, or constituency. For a leadership team, the most salient forms of diversity are rooted in their constituency's identity: young, older, old; those who work at home, at the office, both places, neither; who are retired; which neighborhoods; degrees of wealth; race; ethnicity; religion; and so forth. The unique skills or experience that a person brings to a team also matters, especially if the interdependence is to be real. This is not a one-size-fits-all approach to team diversity, but when there is agreement on shared purpose or core values, the more diversity the better.

Three Decisions for an Effective Team

An effective team has established a shared purpose, clear ground rules or norms, and interdependent roles.

When a team has a shared purpose—a what, who, and how—it is rooted in the shared values, interests, and resources of its members: *what* is our common goal, *who* are our people, and *how* (through what kinds of activities) will we get it done.

Without a shared purpose, every decision relitigates what our purpose really is. Or we assume our version of the purpose is everyone's version of the purpose. In bureaucratic organizations, a superior may simply assign a purpose to a team. Self-governing leadership teams, on the other hand, must accept responsibility for deciding on a purpose themselves, even if their purpose is nested within broader organizational goals. And it is work they must do.

Recently, with my colleague Abel Cano, I was asked to work with members of an emergent movement of community labs, based at MIT, whose leadership wanted to define a shared purpose. Their proposal was to survey their members; gather data on values, interests, and resources; and turn it over

to an algorithm capable of convergent and divergent processing. Voila! Out would come their shared purpose. Although I'm intrigued by the potential of digital technology, I had to point out this would be the shared purpose of the algorithm, not the shared purpose of their people. If their people were to own a shared purpose, they would have to do the work: hear each other, learn with each other, debate their differences, identify their commonalities, and come to an agreement for which they would be responsible. Aggregating many individual preferences is not the same thing as engaging with each other to come up with a whole that can be greater than the sum of its parts.

One way we've learned to do this is to ask each member of the team to write one sentence in which they describe how they see the goals, constituency, and activities of the team. Each person is then asked to read their sentence out loud. A facilitator notes key words on a poster or screen in one of three columns: goal, constituency, and activities. The facilitator then leads the group first in synthesizing what is shared and clearly differentiating what is not. The group can then hear arguments as to the differences and decide. Then they write a second round of sentences, which usually produces more convergence. After a similar exercise as before, the facilitator tries to focus the group on where the most energy and other key elements seem to be shared. The facilitator chooses the sentence closest to the whole. Rather than wordsmithing the sentence, the facilitator asks its author to come up with a proposal. The reason this works is that we usually begin our discussions of shared purpose from our differences rather than our commonalities. We may all care for the natural world, but I'm for whales, you're for trees, and a third person is for dealing with carbon emissions. That sets the context for our work. In contrast, the process I've described begins by identifying areas of convergence, which then become the context of our work. This approach makes resolving our differences less arduous: after all, in the previous example, we're all for saving the environment.

When a team has established norms for decision-making, honoring commitments, managing conflict, and respecting time, it has accepted responsibility for self-governance. Norms are not just rules. They are explicit expectations about how you will work together, how you will make decisions, how you will manage your time. What are things you will always do, and what are the things you will never do? And how will you correct yourselves if you fail?

Perhaps a team's most important norm is how the team will make decisions. Effective decision-making can be supported through a stepwise process

of defining the problem, establishing criteria, brainstorming possibilities, synthesizing ideas, formulating options, evaluating options against the criteria, and deciding. Some prefer deciding by vote; others, by consensus; others, by delegating the decision to an individual.

Norm-setting is an exercise in self-governance for which the team must take responsibility. If these ground rules are not clear from the beginning, every substantive debate can easily turn into a process debate, leading to irresolution, anxiety, and frustration. Norm-setting is a constitutional moment, the only moment in which consensus is required if the team is to move forward. Taking the time to do this is an investment in the health, effectiveness, and future of the team.

Norm-setting often involves explicitly setting aside a regular time for meetings, learning, and coaching. Regular team meetings can become the eye in the hurricane, a source of order at the core of what can feel like a chaotic enterprise. But this time must be sacred. When I was coordinating the organizing for Nancy Pelosi's first campaign for Congress in 1987, I looked for an opportunity to establish this practice. We had just begun our daily coordinators' meeting when someone came running into the room shouting, "Nancy's on the phone! Nancy's on the phone! She's got to talk to you right away!" All eyes turned to me. Was our time really sacred, or not? "Please tell Nancy that we're in our coordinators' meeting," I said. "I'll call her as soon as we're done." "But, but, but," came the response. Again, "Please tell her I'll call her as soon as we're done." A big sigh of relief. From that point on, we never had any problem sticking to our daily meeting.

Norms only really exist in practice. Norm violations that have no consequences redefine the norm. We agree to meet at 10:00. Someone wanders in at 10:30. No one says anything, instead looking down at their feet. A new norm has been created: roll in by 10:30.

Some members of a team resist the idea of a norm correction. It is a way a team can share responsibility for accountability, rather than assigning policing to one member who has to take all the heat. A correction need not be onerous or burdensome; you don't need to assess a huge fine every time someone is late. The best norm corrections are often humorous. If someone is late, perhaps they need to do a ten-second dance to a song of their own choosing. Correcting norm violations is not about public shaming. It is about reminding others about the responsibility of respecting our own commitments.

When a team uses interdependent roles to organize its work, each member has responsibility for their own share of the leadership work needed to achieve the goal. Role requirements need to be clearly described. Even though roles are likely to evolve during a campaign, roles must be set in the first meeting. The idea is to match needs with abilities, rather than making role assignments a popularity contest, a test of who has the most power, or a test of meeting criteria other than those most relevant to the particular responsibility.

When roles are designed to be interdependent, everyone has a stake in everyone else's success. Team members speak up when they need help, and they get it. No one works in a silo that's secretive to others. And everyone swarms to the need. A team of diverse identities, experiences, and resources brings more to the table than a homogeneous team. To the extent that leadership teams define the same basic roles across levels and locations, they facilitate parallel role-based online learning, peer coaching, and adaptation.

Leadership teams often struggle with deciding whether to design roles based on function or on constituency. But if one's mission is organizing, roles are better defined by constituency: the west side of town, the east side of town, the colleges, and so on. In this way, each leadership team member can own responsibility for their own constituency, which they organize by building relationships, developing leadership, coaching the campaign, and so on. This basic structure can be supplemented with functional roles especially suited for event management, such as the data person, the media person, the training person, the fundraising person, the special events person, and so on. This approach works well for organizing an event but not for organizing a community. Depending on the size of the campaign and the team, these roles may be combined with functional roles, but any functional structure will dilute the focus on organizing. By extension, a team responsible for a particular function, like data management, could build their own data management team.

One caution is that the work of the team will necessarily prioritize the concerns of its members. When I was leading a statewide campaign in California, my team included a coordinator for the Bay Area, another for San Diego and Orange County, another for the rest of the state, and three for Los Angeles, which was subdivided into three regions. Why did LA have three? Three times as many voters lived in LA than in any one of the other areas, and I wanted to be sure that reality would be reflected in our meetings. We also had a person handling administration, another for press, media, and so

on. In this way, our leadership team structure managed to simultaneously fulfill functional roles and represent the constituency to the greatest extent possible.

* * *

The decisions that must be made to structure an effective and collaborative leadership team can be stressful. Inevitably, people will disagree over goals, responsibilities, norms, and procedures. A lesson we have learned from launching leadership teams all over the world is the importance of launching with the heart as well as the head and hands. Finding ways to celebrate, to build an emotional connection, can be a way to restore emotional harmony to the team after what may have been a moment of contentious debate.

Every team needs a name, so why not start with brainstorming possible team names? Some suggestions will be descriptive—Green Team—while others will be values-based—Just Organizers—while others draw on shared jokes or cultural experiences—Justice Jedis or 7 Deer Dancing or the Love Gas Station. The creativity, humor, and consensus building involved in choosing a name begins to create the experience of a shared identity rooted in values shared by the team.

A team chant takes this one step further, often producing lots of laughter, loss of self-consciousness, healthy humbling (but not humiliating), and creativity. Chants have also included elements of dance; the most creative I've seen was in an organizing workshop in Beijing. People can move around after what may have been a long day. And team members perhaps not as engaged in the head and hands work may really flourish here, finding new ways to contribute to the team as well. It's fun, it's expressive, and it works.

Distributed Leadership: Getting to Scale

So far, this chapter has focused on collaborative leadership teams as a core organizational structure. These teams, however, form the core of a far greater distributed leadership development process. One way organizations can begin distributing leadership is for each member of the core leadership team to accept responsibility for organizing their own leadership team.

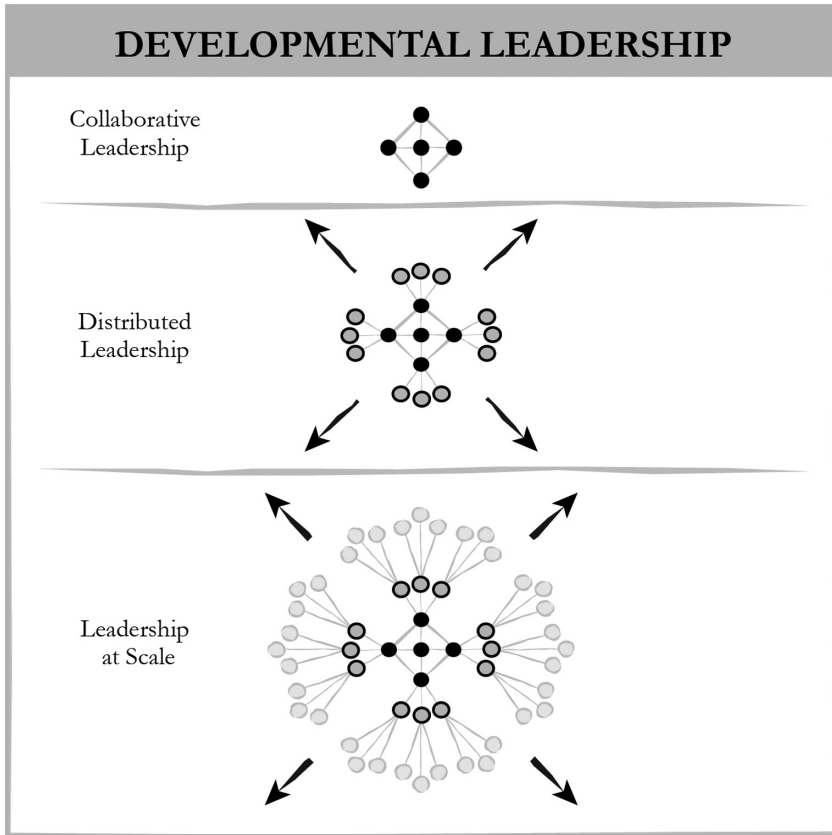


Figure 7.2 Developmental Leadership (previously appears in chapter 1 as Figure 1.9). *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Each member of those teams can, in turn, build their own team and on and on. Because of the team structure that radiates from the center out, many organizers describe this approach to leadership development as creating a snowflake or snowflaking out. We now turn to how to build your snowflake out (Figure 7.2).

Developmental leadership, if it is to be real, must be structured in a spirit of risk-taking, learning, and adaptation. Leadership development—like any form of trust—involves risk. You may delegate to the wrong people, and they may let you down. But as Moses learned from Jethro, if you fear delegating, you will stifle growth in the power of your organization. You can increase the odds of success by building practices designed to identify, recruit, and develop leadership systematically into the work you do each day (Figure 7.3).

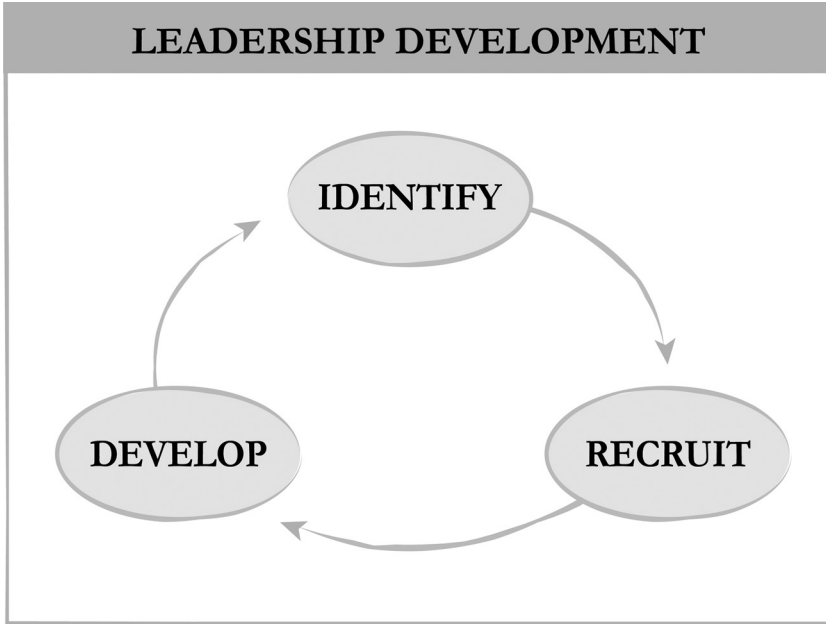


Figure 7.3 Leadership Development. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Identifying Leadership

An organizer's job is to find leadership or potential leadership from within their constituency, leaders who can identify, recruit, and develop others. Here, leaders need to be aware of their own cultural biases, as we have all absorbed culturally specific lessons about who is and isn't a natural leader. Leaders should also realize that some people may want to identify themselves as leaders based on little more than their own self-confidence. So it is important to identify leadership based on the evidence.

I recall one experience in the farmworkers, getting started in a new town. My colleague and I were confronted by three people who claimed to be the leaders of the community. "Great," we said. "How about getting twenty or thirty community members, especially the most active, so we can meet them tonight?" How many do you think showed up? Zero. Not even the three leaders. This is what the farmworkers called leadership "de los dientes pa'fuera"—from the teeth outward.

Sometimes in these situations, it eventually became clear that the de facto leaders were biding their time, waiting for more information to judge for

themselves whether they should put themselves—and the people who rely on them—at risk. Sometimes the individuals who had earned the least respect, built the fewest relationships, and are the most eager for outside support were the ones who showed up first. If you misidentify these folks as existing leaders, you can end up orienting your organizing effort around those least representative of the people you hope to organize.

So how do you identify leadership? Leaders are people committed to change, open to learning, in relationship with others, and able to accept responsibility for the hard work of organizing. They are not RPs—the “real people” campaign consultants sometimes conjure up to legitimate their candidates. They are people who step up to form the backbone of an organizing campaign. They must be people whose candor you can trust, to whom you can delegate real responsibility, and on whose commitments you can count.

Based on their experience, do others look to them as leaders? Do they turn out the people for the meeting? Do they get the petition signatures? Do they pose challenging questions? Identifying leadership is a process of looking at the facts, at deeds, not words.

Recruiting Leadership

We only develop good judgment about who to recruit by taking risks, making choices, experiencing success and failure, and learning from the whole experience. And even then, we will still be surprised. The more experience we can draw on, the better the judgment we can develop—if we are paying attention. There is no rule book, but if you fear making bad choices, you cannot learn to make good choices.

Here are some questions you might ask yourself: How do you select to whom to delegate? How do you know who the right person is? How can you find out ahead of time? How do you know when a person is ready for a big job? Do you select them because they are available, or do you select them because they are the right person to do the job? Do you select them because you know from past experience that they will know what to do, because they look like they will know what to do, or because they could—and want to—learn what to do? Do you select them because you heard they were good? Where did you hear that? Who told you? Should you believe them? How do you know? As you can see, there are lots of questions that need to be asked.

Risking small failures early in a campaign helps avoid big failures later. When you risk learning to delegate, you also learn to judge who may come through and who won't. It is wise to learn this lesson when something small is at stake—say, a small meeting instead of a monster rally. Quantifiable goals, regular reports, and ongoing evaluation processes enable leaders to detect failure and success early on so that they can become learning opportunities for everyone. “So, Mary, why did that work so well?” “So, Sam, what happened there? What could you have done differently?”

As in any beginning, there will be successes and failures because you are still learning. It may even be unclear what the right way is when you begin a new project. You can turn this fact to everyone's advantage if you can find the courage to risk sharing responsibility with others for outcomes you care about.

Developmental Leadership

Sustained and systematic leadership training—or formation—is a key component of leadership development. It can clarify expectations, build your members' confidence in accepting leadership roles, and express the value you place on leadership, competence, and learning.

Initial training sessions can onboard new people, enroll them into an organizing culture, and enable them to build relationships with each other. You can also use trainings to introduce core practices, develop teaching skills, and launch new leadership teams. This is how we used our two-and-a-half-day Camp Obama training sessions in 2007 and 2008. At the first one, held in a sound stage in Burbank, California, in July 2007, we hosted more than two hundred volunteers selected from among those who had applied online. They arrived Friday afternoon as individuals but left Sunday afternoon as members of leadership teams. Each had committed to specific goals, including the goal of recruiting at least twenty people to come to their first meeting back home. We introduced them to the five leadership practices (relationship building, storytelling, strategizing, acting, and structuring) and equipped them with basic technical skills (how to use voter files, media, digital skills, etc.). The training enabled them to take responsibility for clear goals within their congressional district, including developing more leadership teams within their district, ultimately down to the precinct level.

Launching leadership with an initial training is thus not just about learning everyone's name, filling out forms, reviewing a manual, and giving out assignments. It is about introducing people to the concepts, skills, and values that can create a foundation for individual and organizational development.

Ongoing periodic training can scaffold further development, enable learners in one session to become teachers in a subsequent session, support improvement in practice as well as adaptive innovation, and provide a venue in which newly salient practices can be introduced.

In the 1988 Democratic Presidential GOTV campaign in California, we hired three hundred organizers to organize 14,000 precincts. We built a multitiered structure led by a five-person core leadership team, seven regional field directors, forty-two coordinators, and about seven organizers per coordinator. Each organizer then had to build their own multitier volunteer organization to deploy GOTV teams in some three hundred precincts on Election Day. As the campaign unfolded, we had to retool—and remotivate—as each new phase arrived. We started with weekday training of regional directors, adapting the plan alongside them; they would retrain their coordinators, and the coordinators would retrain the organizers, who would then relaunch their volunteer teams in a weekend event. This, alas, was in the era of yellow legal pads, WATS unlimited-use phone lines, and lots and lots of printing. How much better (and cheaper) the whole thing could be done today using online tools like Zoom, which enable face-to-face training with large groups, breakout groups, and zero travel.

The point is that we found a way to combine leadership development, training, and action at some depth on a large scale. Although this effort was not enough to swing the California of 1988 into the blue column, it did result in almost a refounding of the California Democratic Party. It's a prime example of how even a losing campaign can be used to develop a more powerful organization.

Structuring Developmental Leadership into the Work

Successful developmental leadership requires structuring it into the work: opportunities, responsibilities, and accountability. You've established leadership teams and have begun cultivating practices for developing distributed leadership. These are important and necessary steps. But

developing leadership isn't something that happens just once in the life of an organization.

Opportunities

Developmental leadership requires structuring opportunities for people to earn their leadership. Since followers create leaders, leaders can't appoint themselves, nor can you appoint them. But you can create opportunities for people to accept leadership responsibilities and support them as they learn how to fulfill these responsibilities. If you had to get the word out for a meeting, in the days before social media, you could get three or four friends to help you pass out leaflets in a strategic location on a campus, worksite, or neighborhood. Or you could recruit two or three people from each residence hall, shop, or precinct to accept responsibility for recruiting five people each. People learning to motivate others to commit to coming to the meeting creates an opportunity for them to earn leadership, even though it requires greater investment of time and effort at the front end.

This process isn't so different for social media. You can rely on Facebook or an equivalent to spread the word. Or you can build a team to reach out to recruit specific people to show up, not unlike the teams Sunrise built to get out the vote for the 2020 presidential election.

Responsibilities

Developing leadership is not about assigning tasks. It is about offering opportunities to accept responsibility. It is the difference between asking, "Would you make these fifty phone calls telling people about the meeting?" and, "Would you take responsibility for getting ten people to come to the meeting?" In the first, you give them a script and tell them what to do. In the second, you give them tools that allow them to figure out how to fulfill their commitments.

When you delegate tasks, you risk turning a person into a yo-yo: go do this, come back for what's next, go do that, come back for what's next. The person is helping you fulfill your responsibility. But if they have accepted responsibility for something, the person takes it and runs with it. Your role is to help them meet their responsibility. In a December 2022 article, civic

journalist Micah Sifry described this as the difference between “entaskment” and empowerment.⁶

When you’re looking for someone to take responsibility for something, don’t try making the responsibility easier, and easier, and easier . . . until there’s nothing left. The challenge for leaders is in learning to motivate people to accept the level of responsibility needed to get the job done. When a person has accepted responsibility, the motivation for the work follows. Keeping others motivated, keeping yourself motivated, and getting the work done all depend on accountability, recognition, and coaching.

Accountability

Responsibility is only real if the person is clearly accountable for the responsibility they accepted. Accountability must be regular, specific, and timely. The point is not to catch someone doing something wrong and punish them for it. Rather, it is to learn what kind of results they are getting so that everyone can learn from them.

If someone is having trouble, we need to learn why so that we can figure out what to do about it. If someone is successful, we need to learn why so that we can try the same thing in other places. Without accountability, the most important learning we can do over the course of a campaign—systematic reflection on our own experience—is impossible. You cannot expect a person to take responsibility without authority. If you want someone to take the responsibility to get ten people to a meeting, hold that person accountable, provide training, and offer support, but then give them the authority to do what they’ve been asked to do. If you see or hear of them making a mistake—or think you can do it better—go directly to them, not around them. Do not take care of it for them. This is really a matter of basic respect.

If you think about it, these guidelines are not that different from the advice Jethro gave Moses some three thousand years ago: Choose people of good character, provide them with education, and give them real responsibility.

Developmental Leadership as Coaching

The understanding of leadership with which I began this book is “accepting responsibility for enabling others to achieve shared purpose under conditions

of uncertainty.” We then focused on organizing as a form of leadership that asks, first, who are my people; second, what is the change they need; and, finally, how can they turn resources they have into the power they need to secure that change. We then dove into learning five practices with which we can do this. There is one more practice, however, with which we can operationalize “enabling others” to excel at all the rest: coaching.

Sustained leadership development requires ongoing and consistent coaching. Formal training sessions only scaffold learning. Real learning grows along with real practice in the field. Traditional on-the-job learning methods, such as, “Throw them in the water and see if they sink or swim” or “Follow me around, kid, and see what I do,” mostly test leaders’ survival skills. This is not coaching. Coaching offers support before, during, and after leadership challenges, allowing leaders to receive constant feedback on their development. I learned by working with a coach who helped me to prep before the meeting, observed me (without intervening) in the meeting, and debriefed me in the coffee shop after the meeting. In the UFW, Fred Ross did this for me—not day in and day out, to be sure, but enough times that it helped me build preparation and critical reflection into my own learning. Through that process, I learned how I could begin to coach others.

Coaching is a direct intervention in an individual’s or team’s work process to help them improve their effectiveness. It is useful whenever we are working to enable others to build their own capacity to act. While contexts vary, the process is very similar.⁷

Coaching to Overcome Three Key Challenges

My mother, who was an educator, early on taught me that the root for education in Latin, *educare*, refers to bringing out, not putting in; to elicit a person’s capacity, not to infuse them with advice. We coach others to improve their effectiveness. Coaching is not about giving advice, preaching, making judgments, or telling someone what to do. It facilitates learning to the extent that it enables people to find the wherewithal to overcome three common forms of challenge—motivational, educational, or strategic—that inhibit performance:

- **Motivational** (heart) coaching is required to enhance effort. Whether the person fears failure, lacks confidence in their own efficacy, or lacks

commitment, the individual lacks the motivation to take the risks needed to learn, to put in the hours needed to practice, or to put in that last ounce of energy needed to cross the threshold.

- **Educational** (hands) coaching is required to enhance acquisition of information or skills. One may not have critical data needed to do the job, the skills required, or the experience to make good judgments.
- **Strategic** (head) coaching is required when someone has the information and the motivation but doesn't know where, when, and how to use that information in this particular context to get the desired result—that's a strategic challenge.

Learning to distinguish among these challenges—and how to intervene successfully—requires learning how to ask questions, how to listen with both the head and the heart, and how to support with both affirmation and challenge. Coaching is not all about praising people for strengths, criticizing them for weaknesses, or telling them what to do. It requires learning to identify a person's strengths and their weaknesses to ally with—or mobilize—the strengths to overcome the weaknesses. Although some coaching may be corrective (telling the other person what to do), most coaching, especially leadership coaching, is developmental (enabling the other person to learn what to do).

Coaching as a practice is most reliable if built into a regular schedule, not on an as-needed basis. If regular, coaching builds learning right into the work. Both the coaches and the quality of the work itself improve. If coaching only happens when needed, people may be reluctant to ask for help to the extent that it signals they don't know what they are doing. In reality, not asking for help when you need it signals you truly don't know what you're doing. But it may take a while to establish this norm. At the same time, if one is summoned for coaching, it can feel a little bit like getting called to the principal's office. All these situations can be avoided by incorporating coaching into the routine.

How Coaching Works: The Five-Step Process

Coaching requires learning how to use three methods to implement five steps. The three methods are to ask questions, listen (head and heart), and support (affirm and challenge). This approach to coaching appreciates the fact that the coachee most often has all the information needed within, but

that information has not yet been articulated—put into words. The coach then applies each of the three methods across five steps (Figure 7.4).

1. Observe: What do I see and hear?

Listen very carefully, observe body language, and ask very focused, probing questions to satisfy yourself that you get the problem. It may take time to get the facts straight. But if you don't understand the problem, you can't help your coachee solve it. Don't be shy about asking specific stubborn questions. This process can help the coachee articulate just what the problem is in a way they may not have before. This process is not only about getting information but about enabling the coachee to articulate what he knows but may not know that he knows.

2. Diagnose: What is the problem?

Getting the diagnosis right really matters. For example, if an organizer is struggling with strategy and you focus on getting them to try harder, the result will only be frustration—or vice versa.

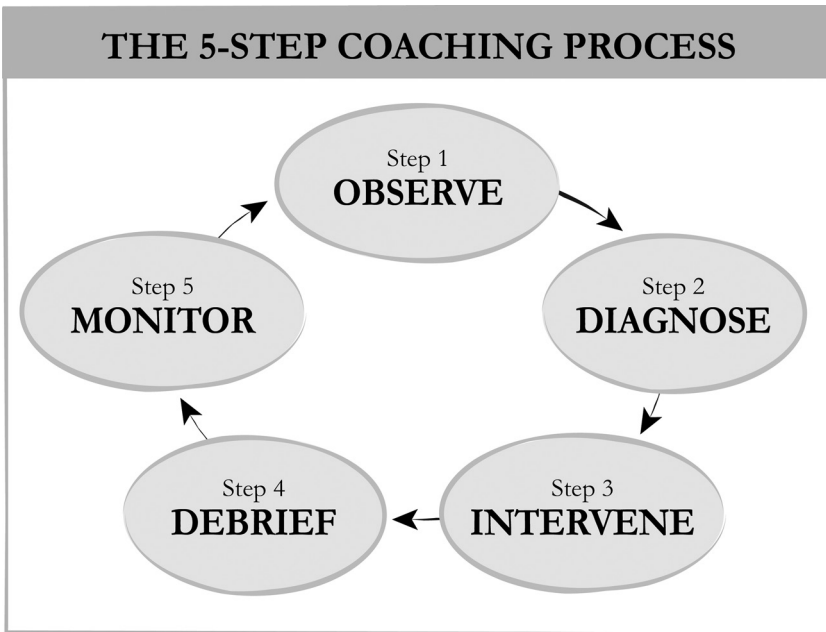


Figure 7.4 The 5-Step Coaching Process. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Is the challenge **motivational** (effort/heart)? Is the individual struggling because they are not putting forth enough effort? Is she not trying hard enough because she's embarrassed? Is he quitting too soon because of frustration or fear?

Is the challenge **educational** (information/skills/hands)? Is the individual struggling because he lacks the skill to execute effectively? Are they getting interference from other habits? For example, someone well versed in marketing-speak may not know how to tell an authentic story. Is it something you could model, or role play with them?

Is the challenge **strategic** (strategy/head)? Is an individual who is motivated and has the skills struggling how to use these skills in this particular context (e.g., an urbanite in a rural area, an immigrant in a nonimmigrant community)? Does he understand the concepts or underlying principles clearly? Has she not thought it through carefully? Are the goals not achievable? Does the strategy make sense?

3. **Intervene:** What do I do?

Once you think you've figured out what the problem is, don't just tell the coachee what you think she should do. Find out what she thinks she should do. Ask questions that enable the coachee to see the problem, that allow you to see how the coachee sees the problem and how she could discern a way to solve it. Get the coachee's views out on the table. The appropriate intervention depends on the diagnosis.

If the challenge is **motivational**, you can encourage and exhort—you can do it! Offer a kick in the pants (with love). Help the person confront their fear, embarrassment, or other emotions that may get in the way of their ability to risk acting, persevering, or trying new things. Communicate with empathy, hope, and affirmation of the coachee's self-worth. Model courage and emotional maturity in your own behavior. Confess fear and explain how you move toward it, rather than away from it.

If the challenge is **educational**, you can model the behavior and invite the coachee to imitate you to get the feel of the activity. You can break it down into small parts and invite the individual to try one part at a time. Offer three or four different practice exercises and observe which ones work best for that person. Suggest others with whom the person can practice or suggest ways to figure out where to find the missing information.

If the challenge is **strategic**, you can work through a specific example with the person, asking questions to guide the strategic process. Then reflect on the process itself, asking them to describe how it worked. Ask

questions about how the individual is thinking about the practice: Why did you choose that tactic? Offer your observations, asking how the person might think about it differently: At that point, were there other options? What might they have been? Why did you choose the one you did? Offer feedback on what you are hearing, asking if that describes the situation and, at the same time, offering possible reframing of it. Use silent reflection and self-diagnosis: Why don't you take a moment to think through what you believe is working and not working and let's talk about that?

4. Debrief: What did the coachee learn?

Ask your coachee to summarize their takeaways from the session. Commit to next steps and decide when you will check back in. What went well? What are you challenged by? What are some possible solutions? What are your goals or next steps?

5. Monitor: How can I continue to support the coachee?

Schedule periodic check-ins to support your coachee in integrating this new or revised solution into their regular practice. Find out from the coachee how the situation has changed. Assess whether the diagnosis and intervention were successful. Celebrate success!

Table 7.1 The Do's and Don'ts of Effective Coaching

Effective coaching is	Effective coaching is not
Showing up and being present to another person's experience, and listening with both your head and heart.	Being so prepared that you work out all the answers for the coachee before you even hear or observe their challenges.
Helping the coachee explore and make sense of their challenges and successes, and what they learned from it all.	Falsely praising of the coachee or only focusing on their strengths because you do not want to hurt their feelings.
Helping the coachee find solutions to challenges.	Solely criticizing the coachee.
Asking questions that both support and challenge the person you are coaching.	Telling the coachee what to do.

In organizing campaigns, new people are usually trying to make new things happen under new conditions, so ongoing learning is essential. Performance feedback, especially on early failures, is critical not only for adapting strategy but also for leadership development. Coaching is a far better option than either micromanagement (telling someone exactly what to do . . . all the time) or hands-off management (sink or swim). Coaching can best be done as part of ordinary leadership practice by embedding it in the work itself. Peers can coach one another with sufficient training in both the coaching and the particular practice itself.

Conclusion

Developmental leadership is at the heart of what makes organizing work. It is not only about enabling others to achieve shared purpose under conditions of uncertainty; it is also about enabling others to enable others to enable others. This is how we build the capacity we need at the scale—and with the depth—we need to create the change that we want. It's the kind of micro work that is required to achieve macro results. It's valuable not only for the goals it makes possible in the future but also because it enriches individual and collective human agency in the present. And if not now, when?